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WEAVING FORWARD

India Couture Week 2026 steps out of the capital and into the city of Nizams **P4**

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
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As if finding yourself in the same room as one of the most venerated filmmakers of the 21st Century was not daunting enough, no amount of mentally preparing to interview the Academy Award-winning mind behind *Oppenheimer*, *Interstellar*, *Inception*, and several other contemporary cinematic landmarks could possibly brace you for how mesmerising Christopher Nolan’s steely blue eyes are up close.

Once I finally snapped myself free from the spell of that impossible blue, it took a considerable amount of steadying my nerves to fully process the fact that I was sitting across from a childhood idol. My mind instinctively raced through the catalogue of wide-eyed cinematic wonder, every memory of witnessing his brand of movie magic on the biggest screen possible rushing back as though I were Cooper stumbling through the Tesseract itself. If only I could reach across that proverbial five-dimensional bookshelf and knock a single book loose, just enough to tell my teenage self that one day I’d be sitting across from the architect of those extraordinary worlds.

But whatever improbable wrinkle in the space-time continuum finally indulged my early cinephilic fantasies, call it fate or *qismat* if you like, the acclaimed British-American filmmaker too seems to be wrestling with a similar sense of destiny through his long-awaited adaptation of Homer’s immortal homecoming epic, *The Odyssey*.

The follow-up to his 2023 Best Picture winner *Oppenheimer* sees frequent collaborator Matt Damon stepping into the sandals of the battle-scarred Odysseus as he struggles to return home in the aftermath of the Trojan War, supported by a formidable ensemble that includes Tom Holland, Anne Hathaway, Robert Pattinson, Himesh Patel, and several of contemporary Hollywood’s most recognisable faces.

The Oscar-winning filmmaker was in Mumbai for his first-ever film premiere in India, along with Damon, Holland, and producer Emma Thomas, drawing droves of fans across the city during the Indian leg of the film’s global promotional tour last weekend. We discussed the formative influences that shaped his latest film, why the story felt like a culmination of his filmmaking journey, and how he continues to protect that first spark of cinephilic wonder while carrying the expectations of millions who now look to his work for that very same feeling.

Excerpts:

Question: Welcome back to Mumbai. It’s been a minute since Tenet. Has your time here brought back any memories since your last here?

Answer: Oh, very much. Just driving into the hotel from the airport, seeing some of the locations we shot at... the city’s changed a lot, but there’s so much that’s familiar. It’s such an amazing, vibrant place. It’s wonderful to be back here.

Q: The *Odyssey* is perhaps the most epic homecoming story ever told, and I was struck by how often your protagonists seem to

Speaking at the Indian premiere of *The Odyssey* in Mumbai, Christopher Nolan reflected on finding destiny in Homer’s immortal epic, adapting a foundational classic, and the mysteries of cultural permanence

The long way home



be torn between this idea of a sense of duty and a yearning for home. Did finally getting to make it ever feel like this is what the Fates had in mind for you?

A: I mean, at the risk of sounding pompous, I think what you’re trying to get to as a filmmaker when you choose a project, you want to feel that there’s some kind of sense of destiny with that. You want to feel that your past and your past work has led you to the film you’re making.

I think I felt that more on *The Odyssey* than any film I’ve made, partly because the story is a foundational literary epic of western literature, and so in adapting it, I found all of my previous films. I found the homecoming narrative from *Inception* and *Interstellar*.

I found the hero’s journey from the *Dark Knight* trilogy, the war story from *Dunkirk*. So much of what I’ve been doing in movies, in some way, comes from this story. So yeah, it did feel... It felt comfortable to me. It gave me confidence that I knew how to tell this story.

Q: While you’ve majorly credited Emily Wilson’s translation as your primary influence, do you have any fond memories of a particularly memorable English teacher or a professor, or even your mum, who I believe was also an English teacher at some point of time, who you would credit for stoking your first interest in *The Odyssey*?

A: Well, I think one of my earliest memories of anything

to do with *The Odyssey* is being at school at about – I think I was four or five years old – and seeing a play put on by the older kids, and it had aspects of Ulysses, as it was then called, being strapped to the masts to resist the Sirens. There was some version of the Trojan horse. I don’t remember much about it, it was a very long time ago, but that’s the first conscious memory

I have of these story influences coming in. But like a lot of people in England and America, over time, through kids’ books, versions of *The Odyssey* itself, you absorb the things in the culture that have become kind of elemental. And then at school, studying the text for the first time and everything. But I actually found coming to the poem as an adult, with the view of adapting it for a screenplay – that was a very fresh experience for me, and I think like a lot of the audience, I wasn’t as familiar with it as I thought I was.

I knew certain elements. I knew things like the Cyclops, or the Sirens, or these kinds of things. But reading the poem, it’s just this incredible adventure story, and I wasn’t that aware of the specifics of it. So trying to make a film that’ll work for somebody who’s really familiar with the story, and work for somebody who knows nothing about it, who’s just coming to it like any other film that you might only have

seen a trailer or something.

Q: Last year, I’m sure you’ve heard that *Interstellar* returned to Indian theatres after a decade, and for a period it was even outperforming local Indian blockbusters, which is quite the feat. As a storyteller, is there any greater compliment than watching your work stand the test of time that way?

A: No, none. I mean, it really is an amazing thing, when something you’ve made years before continues to have a life. And people tell you they’ve got something from it, a new generation of filmmakers who possibly was too young to see it when it first came out, or in some cases wasn’t even born when it first came out. That’s how long I’ve been doing this now. It’s really wonderful to see your work stand the test of time. There are so many different variables when you release a film, and I’m very aware of this right now, because I make films for a cinema audience. And so the film, for me, like *The Odyssey*, is not finished until it goes to the audience, and the audience sort of tells me what it is. And there are so many variables that go into that process, in terms of how a film is distributed, who it reaches, and when it reaches those people. So it’s been really gratifying to

(Clockwise from below) Christopher Nolan with cinematographer Hoyte van Hoytema on the set of *The Odyssey*; a still from the film; and the director. UNIVERSAL PICTURES AND GETTY IMAGES



The current thinking is that the poem was handed down as oral poetry for hundreds of years before it was even written down. These are incredible mysteries, and they make you think a lot about what endures in human culture, and whether or not film can have that kind of permanence as a medium. I mean, it’s only about 100 years old. Can it have that permanence as a medium, or is it fleeting, like theatre? And I think in some ways it’s too soon to say.

Bun maska and Bollywood

● Matt Damon, who plays Odysseus, described the film as one of the most meaningful projects of his career and recalled being overwhelmed by the sheer scale of its production, joking that he had asked producer Emma Thomas, “I can’t believe you decided to produce this movie.”

● Tom Holland remembered walking across the Moroccan set on his first visit and feeling as though he had “gone back in time,” calling the experience unlike anything he had ever witnessed.

● Before stepping onto the red carpet however, Nolan, Damon and Holland dropped by Olympia Coffee House in Colaba, Mumbai, one of the city’s oldest surviving cafés, where they enjoyed cups of chai and the iconic bun maska. Photographs shared online quickly went viral, showing the trio seated around the café’s iconic marble-topped tables.

● The celebrations later continued with the film’s India premiere, attended by members of the Indian film fraternity, including *Tenet* actor Dimple Kapadia.

see *Interstellar* continue to have a life for a new generation of filmmakers.

Q: This sort of afterlife also feels analogous to *The Odyssey* itself, and how it’s endured the test of time. Has the film changed the way you think about what it really means for a story to endure?

A: That’s a very interesting question. I think it has in ways that I haven’t fully processed yet. It’s pretty remarkable to be reading words that are a translation of something that was written down so long ago. And the fact that these words have carried for thousands of years in different ways, and thinking a lot about where the words have come from, how they’ve been transmitted. I mean, the thing about *The Odyssey* that is incredibly compelling is, you know, words give you a very direct relationship with the author of the piece, but nobody knows who or what Homer was. They don’t know if it’s one person or multiple people or whatever.

Q: When you meet someone who tells you that your films are the reason that they got into cinema, do you ever feel a sense of responsibility to protect that first sense of wonder?

A: I do. And my context for that is the great filmmakers who I was inspired by as a kid, like George Lucas, Ridley Scott, and Stanley Kubrick, and all these great filmmakers that I grew up with, watching their films. And that, as you say, that ‘first sense of wonder’, that idea, you know, you go to a cinema as a child, and the screen is so huge, and it transports you into a world that shows you all these other possibilities. I think the reason I shoot on IMAX is I want to have the biggest screen possible, I want to have the most immersive experience possible, because I want to get back to that feeling that I did have first experiencing cinema.

The *Odyssey* is now in theatres.

pick of the week



Scent of memory
Samantha Ruth Prabhu's perfume brand, Secret Alchemist, is bringing sandalwood back into focus with its latest fragrance. Sandalwood Nostalgia blends Italian bergamot, cherry blossom and Australian sandalwood. Already available online, the fragrance from the brand's Everyday Essentials range will be unveiled in Chennai at Eventide Coffee, ECR, on July 18. Priced at ₹1,499, it is available on secretalchemist.com.



Heritage meets art
Art, craft, and heritage come together in DakshinaChitra's latest line-up of exhibitions and public programmes. Art of the Book (July 18 to September 6) explores the intersection of image, text, and environment, while Expressions (July 22 to August 3) celebrates Tamil Nadu's living performance traditions. Vastra Utsav takes place on July 31 to August 1, the Children's Heritage Quiz follows on August 27, and many more events. At DakshinaChitra, East Coast Road.



Flo at Folly
If you are looking to refresh your wardrobe, FICCI FLO Chennai revives its flagship FLO Bazaar after nearly a decade, bringing together labels including Heritage Patan Patola, Richa Goenka, Rosette Attire, Naksha, Sanchi, Aarni, Style Aura by Ruchi Kocchar, and CAVASA. Discover handloom weaves, contemporary fashion, jewellery, beauty, and artisanal foods while supporting women entrepreneurs and MSMEs. At The Folly, Amethyst, on July 24 and 25.



Feel the beat
Trade your Saturday evening for an energetic celebration of rhythm as Jus Drums School of Percussion marks its 24th annual concert tomorrow. Watch students take the stage in a lively showcase of drum ensembles and percussion performances under the guidance of S Muralikrishnan, with Carnatic vocalist Sudha Ragnathan presiding over the evening. At TAG MFAC Auditorium, Mylapore, on July 18, 6.15pm. Entry is free and open for all.



THE NAKED TRUTH

Barry Rodgers
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Bengaluru has never encountered a human interest it could not turn into a community. There are groups for runners, sourdough enthusiasts, amateur astronomers, and founders recovering from the emotional consequences of founding. It follows, then, that if you are polyamorous, poly-curious, interested in kink or simply wondering whether monogamy's terms and conditions deserve a closer read, there is probably a WhatsApp group for that too.

The city's contribution to modern intimacy may not be sexual liberation so much as giving desire an organisational structure. There are workshops devoted to kink, mixers for people exploring alternative relationships, rope jams (a social event where participants practice tying, share knowledge and connet) centred on consent and trust.

Bengaluru appears to have created what many Indian cities still struggle to offer: spaces where unconventional desires can become ordinary enough to discuss without shame.

When Sri, 29, moved to Bengaluru from Coorg in 2023,

Bengaluru's love stack

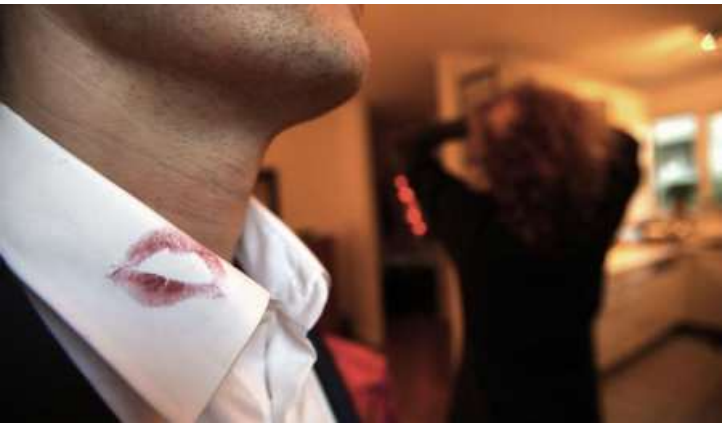
The city is rethinking the relationship status, suggesting that love no longer has to follow a prescribed script

he had already spent years wondering about kink and power exchange without possessing much of the vocabulary to describe either. "You spend years wondering if certain desires make you strange because you never hear anyone talk about them," he says. During earlier visits, he had sought out niche events and workshops, once even arranging a session with a professional dominatrix visiting from Southeast Asia. What surprised him after moving was not that these spaces existed but how unremarkable entering one could feel.

"I don't think the city made me interested in these things," he says. "I was always interested. The city just permitted me to be curious

without feeling like I had to hide." Perhaps Bengaluru's peculiar talent is not persuading people to become different but allowing them to discover that they were never strange to begin with. The numbers, although they deserve the usual caution afforded to surveys commissioned by dating platforms, suggest that this openness extends beyond a small subculture. A 2025 Gleeden-Ipsos study found that 70% of respondents in Bengaluru were accepting of open marriages, consensual non-monogamy, and polyamory, while 21% said they were already in such relationships. Bengaluru is also extra-marital dating app Gleeden's largest market in India, accounting for roughly

Alternative relationships are less taboo in the city. GETTY /ISTOCK IMAGES



18% of its four million users in the country. Sybil Shiddell, Gleeden India's country manager, attributes this partly to a population of professionals working long hours in technology, finance, and consulting. "You still love and respect your partner, but sometimes it begins to feel like you're living separate lives or with a roommate," she says. Dating apps, in that context, become a relatively frictionless route to novelty, companionship, or emotional connection. Bengaluru is a city of migrants, many of whom live at a useful distance from relatives and the auntie surveillance network. Puducherry-based sexuality coach Pallavi Barnwal, who hosts sexual wellness workshops in the city, says many of her Bengaluru clients appear less concerned with managing appearances and more willing to discuss desire, vulnerability, and dissatisfaction. "There's less pretence and concern about being judged," she says. What distinguishes the city may also be who feels comfortable entering these spaces. At events organised by The Intimacy Curator, which supports alternative intimacy through events, applications in Mumbai can skew dramatically male, with 300 to 400 men applying against only 20 to 30

women. At the same time, Delhi sometimes sees as few as 10 female applicants. Bengaluru, by contrast, approaches a near-even gender split. Founder Aili Seghetti says participants in the city tend to be "more informed and articulate about what they're looking for, and more comfortable with the vocabulary of consent and kink" than those she typically encounters elsewhere. The city's openness, however, did not emerge overnight because tech workers discovered therapy vocabulary. Arundhati Ghosh, author of *All Our Loves: Journeys with Polyamory in India*, traces it to decades of queer, feminist, Dalit, arts and civil-society organising, whose communities frequently overlap rather than remain in separate social worlds. Its polyamory communities, including Bangalore Polycules and Polyglamoropolis, are not merely dating pools but networks of friendship, care and practical support. "You don't feel like you have to prove anything," she says. "That makes it easier to be different, because difference itself doesn't feel particularly remarkable." A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



(Clockwise from left) Kalyani Pramod; the great Indian bustard; and the red panda. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Conservation stories

From the great Indian bustard to the yellow-breasted bunting, Kalyani Pramod's fibre artworks put the spotlight on endangered wildlife

Priyamedha Dutta
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When artist Kalyani Pramod speaks about her work, there is a quiet optimism of not having to change the world but make a difference. There is no call for dramatic protests; instead, she believes in the power of art to make people pause, observe, and introspect the world around them. "I don't believe in protest marches alone," she says. "Art is a great medium for creating awareness. It can tell people, subtly, that these are the areas of concern." That philosophy is reflected in The Last Glimpse, her upcoming solo exhibition at Alliance Française of Madras, opening on July 18. The mixed-media textile exhibition brings together 73 artworks inspired by endangered species from across the world, each crafted using discarded materials such as textile scraps, metal wires, construction waste, newspaper and found objects.

Through crochet, weaving, embroidery, punch needle, and sculptures, Kalyani transforms waste into portraits of birds and animals pushed towards extinction by human actions. Kalyani began with the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List (a global database that assesses the conservation status and extinction risk of plant and animal species), studying not just endangered animals but the specific threats each one faces. By the time she was done with The Last Glimpse, she says, the number of endangered species had nearly doubled. However, species such as the ibis and blackbuck, once critically endangered, have now shown signs of recovery through sustained conservation efforts. "In this exhibition I am trying to say that if we do act upon it, we can save some," she says. In all her conversations, hope seems to be a constant. Hope, however, is balanced with stark reminders of human impact. One work on the great



Indian bustard incorporates electrical wires to highlight the bird's fatal collisions with overhead power lines. Another references the migratory bird the yellow-breasted bunting, whose population has plummeted because of hunting. Yet another piece evokes coral bleaching and the collapse of marine ecosystems. "People first get attracted by how beautiful the bird or animal is," she explains. "That is when the concern

starts." Her choice of materials carry a message of its own. "My biggest source is the *kabadiwala*," she laughs. "I've always told my students to look into their dustbin. A lot is waiting there. It also shows how much consumerism is working," says Kalyani. Although The Last Glimpse centres on wildlife, it also reflects her lifelong engagement with social causes. As a textile designer, she worked closely with weaving clusters across Tamil Nadu, advocating for craftspeople long before environmental conservation became her primary focus. Kalyani hopes that her textile practices keep fibre art alive in India through exhibitions like these, since it is often dismissed as craft rather than contemporary art. "I feel there is no art without craft," she adds. "And there is no craft without art." As climate change intensifies, forests burn, and species disappear, she believes that conservation cannot remain an abstract idea. "We have to protect and preserve. It is for our good." The Last Glimpse will be on from July 18 to 31 at Alliance Française of Madras, Nungambakkam. Entry is free and open to all.

Park Street prelude

The Hindu's Lit for Life Unplugged brings Trincas' history alive in Kolkata with Usha Uthup. Join us

Shreya Banerjee
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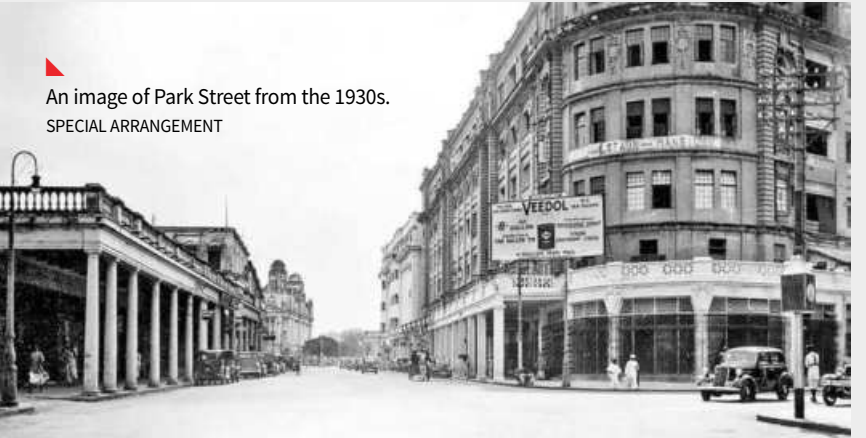
"Trincas is like home to me. It is my mandir, my masjid, my girija. It is my hallowed ground," says legendary singer Usha Uthup, summing up a relationship that has endured for more than five decades. On July 19, that relationship will take centrestage at The Hindu's Lit for Life Unplugged, when Usha Uthup joins historian Anand Puri, third-generation custodian of Trincas, for When Park Street Sings: A Conversation on Music, Memory & Kolkata. Moderated by The Hindu's Associate Editor Shonali Muthalaly, the evening will revisit Usha's musical journey while tracing the history of Trincas and Park Street. Established in 1927 as a Swiss confectionery and tea room by Quinto Cinzio Trinca and Joseph Flury, it evolved into the beating heart of Kolkata's live music scene. Its tables welcomed industrialists, maharajas, actors, cricketers and musicians. Before international fame, Engelbert Humperdinck and Biddu Appiah performed here. In the 1980s,

members of British rock band The Who walked into Trincas only to discover a live band playing their own songs. The evening will also revisit Anand Puri's grandfather discovering a young Usha Iyer at a hotel conference in Madras in 1969 and inviting her to perform on Park Street through an inland letter that changed the course of Kolkata's musical history. The conversation will also trace Usha Uthup's memoir, *The Queen of Indian Pop*, published by Penguin Random House, alongside Anand Puri's forthcoming book chronicling 100 years of Calcutta through Trincas.

Lit for Life Unplugged, part of The Hindu's Lit for Life festival, comes to Trincas on July 19 at 4.30pm. With only 100 seats, entry is free with prior registration. Drinks and food are on you, the stories are on us.



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An image of Park Street from the 1930s. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Kabukicho pass illuminated at night in Shinjuku district; a local grocery store; the Senso-ji Temple; diners at a ramen shop in Tokyo; and a snapshot of Four Seasons Tokyo. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



Tokyo

in two days

Ramen beneath a train station, o-mikuji stall, immersive art and tuna onigiri from the neighbourhood konbini – how much can we cover in 48 hours?

Priyadarshini Paitandy

Tokyo is like my heartbeat after 40 minutes of cardio: Elevated, it makes you feel charged, alive, energetic. It is a city you devour sensorially. How much can you do in 48 hours if you are short on time, like me?

DAY 1

9am: I normally sleep with the blinds drawn. But at Four Seasons Hotel Tokyo at Otemachi, I fall asleep to the twinkling city lights and wake up to clouds making way for the prima donna – Mount Fuji. After marvelling at the snow-capped wonder, through the large windows of my room, I head for breakfast to Pigneto on the 39th floor of the hotel.

The buffet spread is as impressive as the views offering cuisines varying from Japanese, Italian, Thai, American, Continental... I pile my plate with a smoked salmon salad and French toast. All fuelled up, I am ready to explore the city.

11am: I head to the traditional Asakusa district known for its shopping and street food. Narrow Nakamise Street, which leads to the Senso-ji temple, is the most popular. The 250-metre stretch is flanked by rows of little shops with traditional red lanterns hanging. There is also plenty to eat: yokan sweets (made of sweet bean paste), ningyo-yaki (sweets filled with red bean paste), eel buns and crepes filled with roe.

Noon: The Senso-ji temple beckons. I catch a glimpse of it beyond the iconic Kaminarimon gate with its large massive red pillars and a huge

red chochin (traditional red lantern) that weighs around 700 kilograms and is replaced every 10 years. The approach to the temple has numerous o-mikuji stalls, where many stop by to ask the oracle for guidance for the future.

2pm: Lunch today is at the basement of a train station. As shinkansens thunder past above us, I queue up for some of the best ramen in this city. This is Tokyo Ramen Street, a collection of 10 ramen shops under one roof. Not one is empty. I wait outside one called Hirugao for about 40 minutes. When it is my turn, I tap a vending machine-like menu and choose from 14 kinds of ramen. My chicken shio ramen has a deliciously salty flavour and comes with salted eggs cured in a premium tare sauce. Inspired by the elderly man next to me, I leisurely slurp my noodles.

4pm: After being surrounded by large crowds, I opt for quiet time at the Kiyosumi Garden where my eyes are treated to acres of green. A water body occupies a large part of the park, with little bridges and stepping stones connecting different parts of the park.

7pm: At teamLab Planets, my phone camera and senses are on an overdrive. This is an international collective where there are different segments displaying immersive art. From silver, reflective, life-size Easter egg-like structures, and large balloons that change colour when you touch them, to colourful rotating bouncing spheres, and stepping stones that test your balance, each exhibit draws you in.

9pm: Set on the 39th floor, Virtu is among the top 50 bars in the world. I try the fig, cognac and spices

which tastes like Christmas in a glass, and has a dash of clarified milk and Japanese black tea.

DAY 2

9am: Today, I sacrifice my large buffet spread at the hotel for breakfast from a nearby konbini to get a feel of the local life. The convenience stores here are referred to as konbini and the options they present are mindboggling. I find the closest FamilyMart and their famichiki (fried chicken) enjoys a cult fan following. But my favourite is the creamy egg sandwich. And if you ask the locals, they will suggest the salmon or tuna onigiri (rice balls). I pick a jiggly soufflé pudding and a rum and rasin sandwich.

11am: The Imperial Palace in Tokyo is where the emperor of Japan

resides. You can opt for a guided tour which takes around an hour and 15 minutes. You can also sit here and take in the grandeur or if you are feeling active, join locals who do a five-kilometre run around the moat.

1.30pm: The tea ceremony has been part of Japanese culture since the 9th Century. While this still is something that fascinates travellers, the British-style afternoon tea is also gaining fans. At The Four Season Otemachi's The Lounge, I sit by the large windows while the hostess gives me a menu that looks more like an art brochure. The seasonal menu keeps changing and is inspired by myriad themes. This time, it is titled Orsay Impressionist Exhibition Afternoon Tea. Created by Pastry Chef Michele Abbatemarco from Est and Executive Sous-Chef Kensuke Kuze, the menu features beverages, a three-tiered stand with sweet and savoury pastries like smoked salmon dill rilletes with bellpepper puree; vanilla bavares, creme brulee and fig confiture; chicken and chestnut pie; pork ham sandwich, grain mustard mayonnaise with burdock cream, spinach jelly, and saffron... Each inspired by paintings of Impressionist artists like Claude Monet, Pierre-Auguste Renoir

7pm: Fancy is the theme of my day today. Dinner is at Est, a one Michelin-star restaurant helmed by French Chef Guillaume Bracaval who has made this city his home. Est stands for emotion, season, terroir. Here, French techniques and flavours come alive with seasonal produce sourced from across Japan. For example, the wagyu is from Miyazaki, cheese from Hokkaido, blueberries from Shizuoka...

9pm: Post dinner it is a toss up between visiting Shibuya and its chaotic but much photographed crossing or just walking around the hotel and discovering local neon-lit izakayas. I go with the latter. A long but pleasant walk leads me to an alley lined with little bars selling alcohol and short eats. This is Yurakucho Yokocho, nestled comfortably under train tracks. I try umesha (a Japanese plum liqueur). It is mostly tart. After a few sips the flavour grows on me. As the night progresses these bars start filling up with mostly locals. I walk down the vibrant alley, find another konbini and then head back to my room with sakura flavoured chocolates.

The writer was in Japan on the invitation of Four Seasons Hotel.

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New Zealand's wildlife evolved in prolonged isolation after the ancient supercontinent Gondwana broke apart roughly 85 million years ago, leaving the islands without terrestrial mammals for millions of years and allowing birds, reptiles, and insects to take up ecological roles that elsewhere belonged to predators, grazers and scavengers. They survive today in fragments across the country.

"For anyone who comes here, there's an innate desire and aspiration for Nature to thrive," says Bodie Tihoi Taylor, standing inside Sanctuary Mountain Maungatautari, a 3,400-hectare ecological sanctuary in the Waikato region of the North Island. Bodie, a cultural educator who leads the sanctuary's Moa Hunter tours, speaks about conservation as a consequence of history.

For Māori communities, the country's wildlife is inseparable from the memory of what was already lost, and the moa remains central to that history.

Across Aotearoa New Zealand, fenced sanctuaries, cave systems, wildlife reserves and coastal rehabilitation projects have become frontlines in a national effort to reverse those waves of extinction.

Rebuilding the mountain
At Sanctuary Mountain Maungatautari, that restoration effort began with the pest-exclusion barrier through which stoats, rats, possums, and other feral predators have been systematically removed so threatened birds can survive. Maungatautari now supports reintroduced populations of takahē, the large flightless rail once feared extinct, alongside tieke, hihi



(Clockwise from left) The yellow-eyed penguin; the tuatara; the kea; and the kiwi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



The weird and the wonderful

From glowworm caves to albatross colonies, a journey through New Zealand's extraordinary wildlife and the people protecting it

tūi, korimako, piwakawaka and North Island robins. The sanctuary estimates it now hosts more than 3,000 kiwi within the protected ecosystem. During walks through the forest, guides regularly point out pītoitoi, or New Zealand tomtits, flitting between branches while kākā circle noisily overhead searching for food.

"It's a sense of responsibility and loyalty and duty," Bodie says, while explaining the Māori concept of

"kaitiakitanga", often translated as guardianship. "There needs to be a balancing between conservation of our modern day and conservation of our ancestral days."

The underground galaxy
Several hours northwest in Waitomo is the Spellbound Glowworm Cave. This special wildlife tourism hotspot sits within the limestone cave systems of the Waikato region, where thousands

of Arachnocampa luminosa larvae illuminate cavern ceilings with blue-green bioluminescence used to attract prey. The species exists only in New Zealand and thrives in humid cave systems.

We descend into the cave wearing helmets and headlamps before boarding a small boat that drifts silently along an underground river. Once the lights are switched off, the ceiling disappears into what looks like an inverted galaxy.

Near the cave entrance, longfin eels gather in the river bends beneath limestone cliffs. Getting to touch one for the first time feels faintly surreal because the eel's body seems almost frictionless under the hand, its skin coated in a slick layer of mucus that turns the animal into something closer to fluid water than flesh.

Midnight foragers
Further South in Christchurch, Willowbank Wildlife Reserve compresses several of New Zealand's endangered species into a single conservation facility that doubles as a breeding centre and public education site.

The reserve's kiwi house remains one of the few places where visitors can observe the nocturnal birds active during daylight hours. Under dim red lighting, North Island brown kiwi, South Island brown kiwi, Okarito kiwi and great spotted kiwi shuffle through leaf litter using nostrils positioned at the tips of their beaks to locate insects underground. Kiwi numbers once exceeded 12 million before human settlement. Current estimates place the population at roughly 70,000.

Willowbank also houses tuatara, the one-of-a-kind reptile often described as a "living fossil" because it represents the only surviving member of an evolutionary lineage dating back

over 200 million years. At the Royal Albatross Centre on Taiaroa Head, we enter a protected mainland breeding colony for northern royal albatross, or toroa, through a long staircase leading to a glass observatory overlooking nesting grounds. The colony at Taiaroa Head remains globally significant because it is the only mainland breeding site for royal albatross anywhere in the world.

Rehab by the sea
Nearby, the Otago Peninsula Eco Restoration Alliance, commonly known as The OPERA, focusses on species already under severe pressure along New Zealand's southern coastline. Austin Hamilton, a ranger with the organisation, describes restoration work centred around yellow-eyed penguins, known in Māori as hoiho, alongside New Zealand fur seals that haul themselves onto rocky beaches around the peninsula.

"Hoiho are one of the rarest penguins in the world, and unfortunately they're dealing with pressures from every direction now," Austin says, pointing to warming ocean temperatures, declining food availability, disease outbreaks and human disturbance as overlapping threats. The fur seals appear considerably less anxious, sleeping sprawled across rocks while tourists edge closer for photographs.

Across these sites, the country's wildlife tourism industry increasingly functions as a public-facing extension of conservation infrastructure. What ultimately distinguishes New Zealand is the degree to which absence shapes the experience alongside presence.

The writer was in New Zealand on the invitation of Tourism New Zealand

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The old heritage buildings of Kolkata rise against the city's skyline like the sturdy chords of an ancient chamber organ. The rise and fall of these architectural reeds lend the city its own music: a composition of memory, loss and renewal.

The 109-year-old Royal Insurance Building in Dalhousie Square, facing the stately GPO, spent decades folded into the city's bureaucratic routine. The building is reflective of early 20th-Century colonial commercial architecture, with strong Edwardian and Classical influences visible in its scale and ornamentation. But on March 27, 2026, the building assumed another personality altogether. Neon pink and blue lights washed over its creaking stairwells as flamenco dancers in high heels gathered on the steps, waiting to burst into performance.

This transformation was part of Kolkata Unforgettable, an experiential tourism initiative led by Shailaja Mundra and her daughter Vasudha Pachisia. Their idea was simple yet compelling. While exploring the city's heritage structures, the organisers realised these buildings could function as "pre-made backdrops" for cultural experiences. The idea emerged from the reality that heritage owners often lack the financial incentive to maintain ageing properties. Their solution was to animate these spaces through fortnightly curated immersive performances that could generate both public interest and revenue.

"Dalhousie, which is the downtown area of the city is dead on weekends despite its architectural richness," says Vasudha. Rather than turning the events into "history lessons", the team blends storytelling, music and dance, making the venue itself the

hero. Past events have included a theatrical production on the history of the GPO, a dastangoi performance on Guru Dutt inside a North Kolkata rajbari evocative of *Sahib Bibi Aur Ghulam*, and a concert inside St John's Church which saw the church's rarely heard pipe organ being played alongside a choir and string instruments.

At the Royal Insurance Building, choreographer Soujit Das and his troupe, Beatbusters, turned the staircase itself into a performance space, with audiences moving through different levels of the building as the show unfolded around them. In between performances, art walker Navpreet Arora guided attendees through the history of the building. "These are not auditoriums. We have to go wild with our imagination and reimagine every venue as a stage," says Vasudha. The events, planned every few weeks, are intended to eventually become self-sustaining, with a portion of the revenue supporting the upkeep of the very buildings they seek to revive.

Across Kolkata, old walls are finding new rhythms, as jazz bars, cultural venues, cafés and performance spaces, sustained by owners

Past forward

Adaptive reuse is giving Kolkata's heritage buildings a vibrant second life



who see restoration not as nostalgia, but as continuity.

Toolbox initiative

Upholding the spirit of restoration and adaptive reuse is Munir Mohanty, co-founder, Skinny Mo's jazz bar and owner of the 109-year-old late colonial building on South Kolkata's Manoharpukur Road.

It houses two of Kolkata's defining haunts: Nutcase, the cocktail parlour, and Skinny Mo's jazz bar, which shares space with a thrift shop.

Munir grew up on Kolkata's Camac Street before moving to the United States for higher studies. Accompanying him, like the lingering jazz tune, were memories of his old city and his enduring love for

music. On acquiring the building in 2019, Munir explains the process of restoration that took him a year, "I had to take all the sewage pipes, electricals and the plaster on the inside and outside out until the building became a brick shell. There was damp all over the building which required repair and then we had to sound proof the building, we used aluminium windows, retained the red oxide flooring and sourced tiles from Bikaner."

To help heritage property owners with restoration and sourcing materials, Aishwarya and her co-founder Hinna Devi Singh created Jugaadopolis, an open-source restoration toolbox initiative inspired by the principles of the circular economy, aimed at empowering citizens to restore and conserve their own heritage buildings.

With bright red walls, curved balconies, khorkhori windows, red oxide floors and wooden shutters, Red Bari portrays an example of the traditional Bengali urban

mansion. The building was acquired by Avantika Jalan and John Grams from barrister Pareshnath Banerjee in October 2022.

Avantika says, "The walls that run through the building are its main structural support. We have really thick walls in the middle of some of our rooms, which give an old home vibe. Given the restrictions, we've managed to host events like baithaks, private parties, alternative dance performances, a Halloween party, workshops and more."

Speaking about the restoration process, she adds, "We built a fire escape and maintained all our fire and food safety standards. To do this we had to ensure the load of the fire escape structure didn't come on the building. We also added a lift in a similar fashion, luckily the building had inbuilt space for us to do these structures as external structures. Plumbing, however, is a challenge. We have to clean our old drains four times more than any normal

establishment. We also didn't change where the water lines were. All lines were replaced but we didn't try and pull water and add bathrooms to the building where older water lines didn't exist."

GM Kapur, general council (GC) member and convener of INTACH West Bengal and Calcutta Regional Chapters, says INTACH is presently working on creating a platform where buyers and sellers can meet and assess whether their requirements align. "Instead of flattening the building, we are in the process of creating a platform where, say, you have a heritage building and, say, I am a seller, so we meet on the platform to discuss and come to an agreement or a deal."

Mapping lost buildings

Unable to point to the numbers of buildings lost, GM Kapur shares a petition filed before the Calcutta High Court where INTACH raised concerns over the fate of several historically significant structures across the city, arguing that heritage protections were being weakened through neglect, redevelopment pressures and, in some cases, attempts to alter or remove protected status. Among the examples cited was the demolished residence of filmmaker Pramathesh Barua, concerns surrounding the future of the Roxy Cinema and questions over the fate of landmark institutional buildings such as the Alipore and Presidency jails. Kolkata's most significant buildings remain vulnerable despite their cultural and architectural importance.

Against this backdrop, adaptive reuse is gaining attention as a more practical route to preservation. Old walls now find new rhythms sustained by owners who see restoration not as nostalgia, but as continuity.



Mountain menu

Chefs behind AOrigins, Rynsan and Lady Aikoare are reclaiming Meghalaya's culinary heritage with fermented bamboo shoots, forest produce and fish chutney

Preeti Zachariah

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When Ahmedaki Laloo was training to be a chef at Manipal University, she missed the taste of her home state, Meghalaya. "I would tell my mom to send some pickles, fermented bamboo shoots, fish chutney, and condiments," recalls the Shillong-born chef, who was recently in Chennai, as a part of Zhouyu Hosts, a culinary pop-up series that brings chefs from across India and Asia to the city.

But, like other people from the Northeast, she often worried about what her peers would think of this food: "of people mocking us and saying

that my food is stinky," says Ahmedaki.

And yet, something changed when she saw how proud her classmates and friends from other parts of the country were about their food.

The realisation had a profound impact on her. After she graduated and worked in several restaurants across the country, she returned home in the winter of 2020 to establish A'Origins, a culinary

enterprise that seeks to bring this region's cuisine to the rest of the world. "I wanted to express myself and tell stories through food," she says.

Like Ahmedaki, chefs with roots in Meghalaya are opting to return to their culinary heritage, opening restaurants in their own state that explore indigenous cuisines in fresh and exciting ways, "bringing local cuisine to new light,

(Clockwise from left) The team at Zhouyu, with Chef Ahmedaki Laloo; smoking meat; a meal at Rynsan; food served at Zhouyu Hosts; a culinary pop-up. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



doing something like what (Peruvian chef and restaurateur, founder of Lima) Virgilio Martínez has done with Peruvian food or (Italian chef and restaurateur, founder of Osteria Francescana) Massimo Bottura with Italian... taking a classic and elevating it to the next level," says Shillong-based chef Reuben Sooting, founder of Lady Aiko, India's first integrated

hotpot and Korean barbecue experience.

"Even 10-12 years ago, the food scene in Shillong was so different. You didn't have as many restaurants and cafes; you never had anyone doing anything with local influences," says Reuben, who believes that the Government policy played an important role in facilitating the change. "The Government is now very heavily focussed on tourism, which includes our food," he says. Ahmedaki agrees. "I am truly grateful that the Government has been focussing on this. We have been able to express ourselves better because the footfall is increasing every year," she says.

For musician and entrepreneur Hammarsing Kharhmar, who co-founded Rynsan in Shillong with his wife, Riyaki Jana, the fact that tourists aren't just coming to Shillong to "look at our beautiful hills and waterfalls or breathe this clean air" is a positive trend. "They're saying that they want to eat our food, something that has changed in the last five or 10 years," says Hammarsing, who believes that people are recognising that Shillong has a rich, produce-forward food culture. "People are very interested in local cuisine," he points out.

The emergence of restaurants like Rynsan, is indicative of a larger shift, according to former journalist and food writer Damini Ralleigh, co-founder of Delhi's Indicā, which, among other things, curates gastronomic experiences that highlight diverse food cultures. "For a very

long time, cuisines have been looked at zonally, as if states are watertight compartments, with no fluidity across borders. But cultural borders are extremely porous, and those nuances get lost when you talk about cuisines in broad strokes," she says.

The Northeast, she feels, is an interesting focal point of this trend. "It flattens an entire region's cultural and ecological history into a monolithic identity, whereas the Northeast, as we all know,

comprises many tribes, languages, ecological and agricultural systems and food traditions," says Damini.

But this perception is changing, she feels, with people more interested in regional culinary nuances, not just in India but globally.

For the Northeastern states, including Meghalaya, this shift is especially significant, since it "allows these communities to reclaim their own narrative. They are no longer represented

by an outsider's lens. It allows them to articulate their own identity and history," Damini says, a view reiterated by Ahmedaki.

"We have always been under the shadow, and it is our responsibility to do justice to what our ancestors have been passing down."

The writer was in Shillong on the invitation of the Seeti Movement, which had its second edition in Meghalaya.

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Haarshini Agarwal

There is something unmistakably different about a temple during the Tamil month of Aadi. Long before sunrise, devotees gather with flowers, lamps and offerings in hand. The air fills with the sound of Vedic chants, the scent of incense and the rhythmic ringing of temple bells. While faith brings each individual to the temple, it is the shared experience of worship that often leaves the deepest impression.

The power of Aadi lies not only in its rituals but also in the sense of collective faith it creates. When thousands of people pray with a common purpose, the experience becomes deeply emotional. In a world where many navigate uncertainty alone, Aadi offers a rare feeling of belonging, hope and reassurance.

According to spiritual practitioner Shankar Iyer, this collective energy is rooted in the significance of the month itself.

“Aadi is one of the most powerful and spiritually vibrant months in the Tamil calendar. It is believed that Divine Mother Shakti’s energy is at its highest, showering devotees with protection, strength and grace,” he says.

He believes this heightened spiritual presence transforms the atmosphere within temples. “Temples resonate with powerful Vedic chants, devotional hymns, lamps and the collective prayers of thousands of devotees, creating an atmosphere filled with positive vibrations and divine energy.”

For many devotees, participating in rituals such as Durga Homam, Chandi Homam, Mahalakshmi Homam, Lalitha Sahasranama Archana and Kumkum Archana is about more than tradition. These rituals become expressions of surrender, allowing people to seek courage during difficult times, pray for

Experience the vibrant spirit of Aadi, where collective devotion, sacred rituals, and temple traditions unite to uplift and heal.



Aadi: The Collective faith in Divine

prosperity or simply find peace in the presence of the Divine Mother.

Yet what draws people back year after year cannot be explained by rituals alone.

“People come to temples during Aadi because they experience a deep connection with the Divine Mother,” says Shankar Iyer. “The atmosphere of devotion, the chanting of sacred mantras, the fragrance of flowers and lamps, and the collective prayers create a powerful spiritual energy that cannot be described in words, it must be experienced.”

Its often describe collective gatherings as experiences that strengthen emotional resilience and foster a sense of community. Aadi reflects this beautifully. Standing shoulder to shoulder with strangers who share similar hopes and prayers reminds

devotees that they are part of something much larger than themselves. Faith becomes not only a personal journey but also a shared human experience.

Shankar Iyer believes this shared devotion has the power to transform perspectives. “Aadi reminds every devotee that sincere faith and devotion can transform fear into courage, difficulties into opportunities and prayers into blessings.”

Having spent years conducting poojas and homams for devotees, he says the greatest blessing lies in witnessing this transformation firsthand.



“For me, Aadi is not just a sacred month, it is a divine opportunity to serve. Every pooja and homam performed with sincerity becomes a bridge connecting devotees to the grace of the Divine Mother,” he says. “Witnessing families pray together, finding peace, hope and spiritual strength through these rituals is the greatest blessing.”

As Aadi unfolds across Tamil Nadu, its greatest offering may not simply be divine blessings, but the reminder that faith grows stronger when it is shared. Whether through a crowded temple, the lighting of a lamp at home or the quiet chanting of a prayer, Aadi continues to unite people in hope, proving that collective faith can be as healing as the rituals themselves.



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“The greatest blessing of Aadi is witnessing people come together in prayer with complete faith. Every pooja performed with sincerity becomes a bridge between the devotee and the Divine Mother. Over the years, I have seen families find peace, hope and renewed strength through these sacred rituals. True worship is not measured by the grandeur of the offering, but by the humility, devotion, and faith with which it is made. When the heart is pure, even the simplest prayer has the power to invite the grace of the Divine Mother.”

— Shankar Iyer
Founder of Divine Mantra

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M

Hindi

Listless hunt for laughs



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For a franchise whose premise is a loud satire of the destructive nature of human greed, the driving force, Indra Kumar, behaves like his desperate protagonists. By pushing the series into a hollow fourth installment, the makers seem to be executing their own creative heist – mining the final ounces of goodwill from a beloved 2007 comedy to secure a quick box-office payout. Ajay Devgn, who has produced the summer adventure, leads a pack of imbecile characters on screen chasing a mythical treasure. The star brings his deadpan energy to the madness as Guddu, who teams up with the eccentric Johnny (Sanjay Mishra) to hunt for a goldmine of laughs. Along the way, they are joined by the aggressive Adi (Arshad Warsi) and the stupid Manav (Javed Jaaferi), who turns simple instructions into absurd situations and treats human bodies as rubber bands. Then there is the anxious Riteish Deshmukh as the greedy Lallan bouncing off the boisterous Paro (Anjali Deshmukh) for an extra-large dose of humour. Ravi Kishan joins the party as a bungling pirate Adhooora, who has his own bizarre plans to take home the loot.

They are masters of the game, yet the script leaves them with absolutely nothing to hang onto. The screenplay works like a comic digest where writer Paritosh Painter has merely swapped out the cover, leaving the inner pages completely repetitive. Instead of crafting a cohesive narrative that leverages their sharp situational wit, the writers strand these veterans inside a fragmented sequence of sketches. They seem to be forced to manufacture energy out of thin air, react to unpolished CGI animals, and recycle dated gags, in which the derriere becomes the literal and figurative focal point.

The cheap CGI tricks not only create absurd encounters with crocodiles, tigers, and octopuses, but they also place characters on structurally impossible cliffs that shatter any illusion of reality. So many scenes lead to the cliff that the film becomes a cliffhanger in its very structure, constantly dangling the audience over a precipice of artificial tension rather than letting the story breathe. After a point, the actors feel like a mirror of the makers, driven by pure, undisguised opportunism.

The franchise is expected to take a tone-deaf approach toward social and cinematic sensibilities. You know, the motivation for the comedy here is body-shaming, but even in the cringe, hyper-exaggerated comedy space, the timing, the structure, and the wit don't consistently come together. The only time it works is when Guddu (Ajay) knocks on the door of his girlfriend, Alina (Esha Gupta), to win over his children, and is welcomed by a couple of ghosts. Then there are fun antics and conversations between Riteish and Anjali, centred on body size, that spark some low-brow humor. Of course, Sanjay Mishra and Javed Jaaferi work overtime to make the slapstick tick, and Ravi gives it all to keep this bloated ship afloat.

While juveniles in all age groups might find some moments of mirth in this mindless entertainment, for the rest, it is a test of patience. As for Kumar, the question is, how about a sequel to *Dil or Ishq*?

Dhamaal 4 is currently running in theatres



A breezy yet underwritten film

Writer-director Aakash Baskaran's breezy coming-of-age drama understands the feeling of unspoken love, but seldom finds the storytelling to match it

Tamil

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For a good part of my adulthood, I have embraced Ilayaraaja's 'Pottu Vaitha' song from 1991's *Idhayam*, often reminiscing about the remnants of a long-forgotten emotion. Talk about the magic a good song can create in a narrative; the song not only revealed to the audience the depths of the secret admiration Raja (Murali) had for Geetha (Heera), but it also became an emotional shorthand for a love that was felt too deeply to be spoken aloud. Now, *Idhayam Murali* comes in 2026, where Murali's son Atharvaa stars as another man who buries his feelings rather than expressing them. And while the makers have repeatedly stated that the two films are anything but similar (they are set in the same world, and one pays homage to the other), the memory of 'Pottu Vaitha' helped yours truly set one simple expectation from *Idhayam Murali* – that it would have the honesty to remind me of that one singular intense emotion.

And writer-director Aakash Baskaran's film offers mixed results in that respect – even the homage to the aforementioned song comes in a scene well-thought-out but with subpar construction. *Idhayam Murali* charms you with an extremely likeable premise to tell a coming-of-age story that sometimes suffers from inadequate substance and struggles to land its high moments smoothly.

Take, for instance, the way Aakash writes about how 'love' blooms for Idhaya (Atharvaa) across three different stages of his life – each arc feels breezy and effortlessly makes you smile, but the scaffolding keeps collapsing as the

Idhayam Murali

Director: Aakash Baskaran

Cast: Atharvaa, Fahadh Faasil, Preity Mukhundhan, Kayadu Lohar

Storyline: A shy young man looks back on the many unspoken romances that shaped his coming of age as an unexpected reunion forces him to confront his past



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narrative progresses. As a child, Idhaya had a crush on his English teacher Geetha (Jonita Gandhi in a cameo), and there's a mix of innocence and a mature sense of responsibility in seeing a young Idhaya help his pregnant teacher during labour.

It's interesting how the magic in human birth seems to be a common theme in these arcs. It is the magic of birth that first breaks Idhaya's heart in high school, when he learns that Sam (Preity Mukhundhan), the girl he'd been secretly admiring, has an identical twin. The sisters, Samyuktha and Samantha, have been swapping places at tuition and on the tennis court, leaving Idhaya unsure which sister he had actually fallen in love with. Later, as a collegegoer, a childbirth allows Idhaya to eventually spend a few moments in solitude with Amutha (Kayadu Lohar), his mutual friend.

Now, while stealing glances is all one could do in a high-school setting, it's disappointing that there isn't enough drama between Idhaya and Amutha – and after a montage song that shows them and their gang of friends going on trips, Idhaya is still stealing glances. Hasn't his definition of love changed in these years? What does he truly like about this girl apart from her looks? Of course, he cannot even bring himself to confess his love, but where does this fear of rejection originate from? A lot of these questions aren't necessary in all love stories, but they become paramount in a coming-of-age story that celebrates the beauty and heartbreak of unrequited love. And even after Idhaya is an adult, and even when he is still clearly not over those unspoken romances, we don't get to understand his psyche beyond a point.

The film does, however, celebrate friendship in many of its colours – because friendship never demands examination. I surely got emotional seeing Atharvaa, Kayadu, Niharika NM, Thaman, Angeline, Sudhakar, Dravid, and Rakshan become that quintessential college gang that promised to grow up

together, only to take paths that may never converge. These are the people who also bring in the much-needed humour quotient to the story. In fact, the arc between former lovers Sachin (Thaman) and Lado (Niharika) showed promise of a peek into a mature equation, and just as you patiently wait for an emotional pay-off, the film once again settles for lesser fruits.

Interestingly, Aakash never tries to do anything out-of-the-box; he shows conviction in the time-tested tropes of the genre, and while that is admirable, not every idea lands, like an eye-rolling last-minute dash to the airport. Idhaya could have also done without a fight scene in a bus. Maybe that time could have been used to show that whole trip from Madurai to Trichy, which proved necessary but we never quite witnessed? The climax of the film feels all the more contrived without building the connecting tissues that justify why Idhaya does what he does – and why a few other characters must suffer their fate.

All that said, if you find yourself willing to forego a lot of these missteps, all credit goes to the fantastic casting – every actor looks and plays the part – and Thaman's breezy tunes that keep things light. The introduction sequence that reminds us of the little pleasures of growing up in the '90s and 2000s was so well-woven into the screenplay and remains one of the most memorable portions of the film. And, of course, there were moments where I found myself swelling with the love that has refused to fade away – but if anything, that is a reminder that while the film understands the feeling of unrequited love, it never builds the emotional depth needed to make those moments linger. *Idhayam's* Murali, a poet at heart, had a song do it for him, but *Idhayam Murali* needed more.

Idhayam Murali is currently running in theatres

An unconventional thriller that fumbles in the final act

Malayalam

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How far would a fallen man go for redemption? If one were to ask Rajeevan (Prithviraj Sukumaran), the protagonist of Nissam Basheer's, *I, Nobody*, he would probably say: from one extreme, reckless act to another. Consequently, the film also takes one on a rollercoaster series of events, which are intriguing and unconventional up to a point until they turn chaotic misfires.

For that matter, almost every other character in *I, Nobody* appears to believe that their redemption arc lies in jumping into an even bigger problem than the one which they are already entangled in, almost as if they gained some pleasure from further tightening the noose around their neck. These are the kind of men who would bring an earth mover to pick a dry leaf which had fallen on their front yard. But then,



we need people like that to create uncommon cinematic situations, which are aplenty in *I, Nobody*.

Rajeevan is a government employee, who accidentally gets entangled in a bank heist. It becomes the starting point of a series of events that would upturn the life of someone who has been having a rather ordinary existence

with his wife Meera (Parvathy) and two children. The incident also serves as the seed for a man-against-the-system narrative, with the unknown entity suddenly finding itself in a spotlight which he didn't yearn for.

Parts of *I, Nobody* even feel like an outburst against certain rumour mongering YouTube channels who

spread false stories against individuals without verification or editorial control. It depicts the real world ramifications of such videos, which are consumed by millions who are hungry for controversies. Nissam Basheer, who with screenwriter Sameer Abdul created the interesting psychological thriller *Rorschach*, this time brings a theme

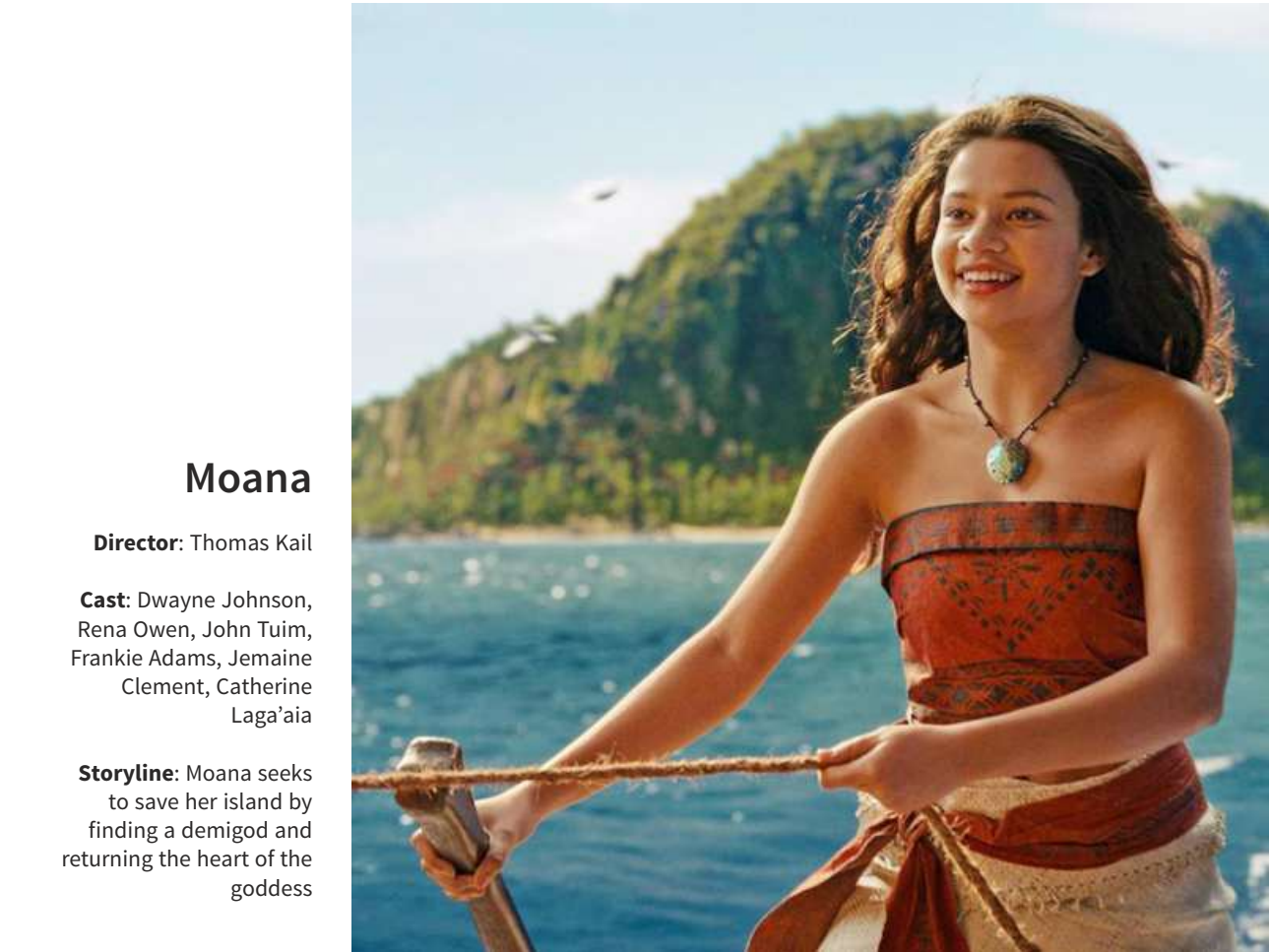
which is closer to the real world, but which still feels far-fetched at times.

Things are quite taut till the halfway point, with the movie taking us to all the unimaginable directions that Rajeevan's mind can travel to. These are some of the best written parts of the film, managing to keep us wholly engrossed. Prithviraj also puts up a restrained act after a long

time, which fits well for the character. Technically, the film is on par with some of the best works from Malayalam cinema in recent years, with slick, thoughtful framing and editing. The action sequences, especially the one inside a flat elevator, also get a novel approach.

Like how some teams have lost their footing due to the hydration breaks in the ongoing FIFA World Cup, the film becomes quite a different, messed up beast post-interval. In its final act, one can sense shades of the spirit of Neeraj Pandey's *A Wednesday* (2008), but unlike that film, which managed to land its message with remarkable impact, *I, Nobody* fumbles a bit. The so-called redemption is achieved through a contrived set of sequences, while the closing scenes makes one wonder what the film really wanted to convey. A film with such a promising opening hour and a half-time high deserved to have a better final act.

I, Nobody is currently running in theatres



Moana

Director: Thomas Kail

Cast: Dwayne Johnson, Rena Owen, John Tuim, Frankie Adams, Jemaine Clement, Catherine Laga'aia

Storyline: Moana seeks to save her island by finding a demigod and returning the heart of the goddess

A soulless remake

English

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Ten years ago, Disney released *Moana*, an animated film about a chief's daughter who sails the ocean in search of the demigod Maui and returns the heart of the island goddess, Te Fiti. The film, a critical and commercial success, had an arresting visual palette, jokes, adventures and songs aplenty, and also created a new breed of Disney heroine.

Moana was not a damsel in distress waiting to be awakened by a kiss from Prince Charming. She was a chief-in-waiting, anointed by the ocean itself to venture beyond the safety of the reef and save her island. There was a sequel, *Moana*

2, in 2024, which was well on the downward slide to mediocrity. Now comes a live-action remake of the animated film, which is stunning only in its soulless replication of frames.

Moana (Catherine Laga'aia), the daughter of Chief Tui (John Tui) and Sina (Frankie Adams) of the Polynesian island of Motunui, is curious and longs to explore the wide ocean. Though her parents dissuade her, wanting to keep her safe, Gramma Tala (Rena Owen), understands the young girl's desire to explore and encourages her to follow her heart.

The people of Motunui worship the island goddess Te Fiti, but when the shapeshifting Maui (Dwayne Johnson) steals her heart to give humans the power of creation, much like Prometheus, Te Fiti disintegrates. A thousand years later, the ocean chooses Moana to return the heart to Te Fiti and set things right.

When the coconuts turn rotten and fish disappear from the sea, Motunui is in dire straits, and Moana decides to set out, find Maui, restore the heart to Te Fiti and save the island.

After many adventures involving the coconut pirates

Kakamora, the treasure-loving crab Tamatoa (Jemaine Clement), and an angry volcanic demon, all comes right.

Laga'aia, who takes over from Auli'i Cravalho, does her earnest best, though she has little room to make Moana her own as the film follows the original shot for shot.

Johnson reprises his role from the animated films but seems to have phoned it in. The wig is rather distracting, while his tattoos are far more animated and get whatever meagre jokes there are to be had. Clement, who also reprises his role from the animated films, sings a jaunty tune while wiggling his eyes in an alarming manner.

Live-action with eerily life-like CGI is a bit of a misnomer. Though shot in Hawaii, the blue of the sea and the expansive lush green vistas do not deliver much of a wow, presenting a sterile lab-grown version of reality. The songs, action, and jokes all give as much joy as microwaved curry puffs from yesterday. *Moana* was an animated gem, which did not need this flat rehashing.

Moana is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Alia Bhatt joins Sohum Shah's Tumbbad 2

Actor Alia Bhatt has joined Sohum Shah's *Tumbbad 2*, the makers announced on July 14. Directed by Adesh Prasad, the sequel to the 2018 acclaimed horror film also stars Nawazuddin Siddiqui in a pivotal role.

Speaking about joining the film, Alia said in a statement, "*Tumbbad* has stayed with me ever since I first watched it. Very few films create a world that feels this original and immersive, and even fewer continue to grow in people's imagination years after they've released. That's what makes this opportunity so exciting."

Tumbbad 2 is produced by Sohum Shah in collaboration with Jayantilal Gada's Pen Studios. It is set to be released in theatres on December 3, 2027.



Apple TV's Nocturne sets October premiere, drops first look

Apple TV has unveiled the first look at *Nocturne*, its upcoming crime thriller starring Liev Schreiber, Zazie Beetz, and Stephen Graham, while confirming that the series will premiere globally on October 30.

Previously announced under the working title *Lazarus*, the 10-episode drama is adapted from Lars Kepler's internationally bestselling novels *Lazarus* and *The Sandman*. The series will debut with its first two episodes on October 30, followed by new episodes every Friday through December 25.

The ensemble cast also includes Bill Camp, Rory Culkin, Chrissy Metz, Poorna Jagannathan, and Gary Carr.

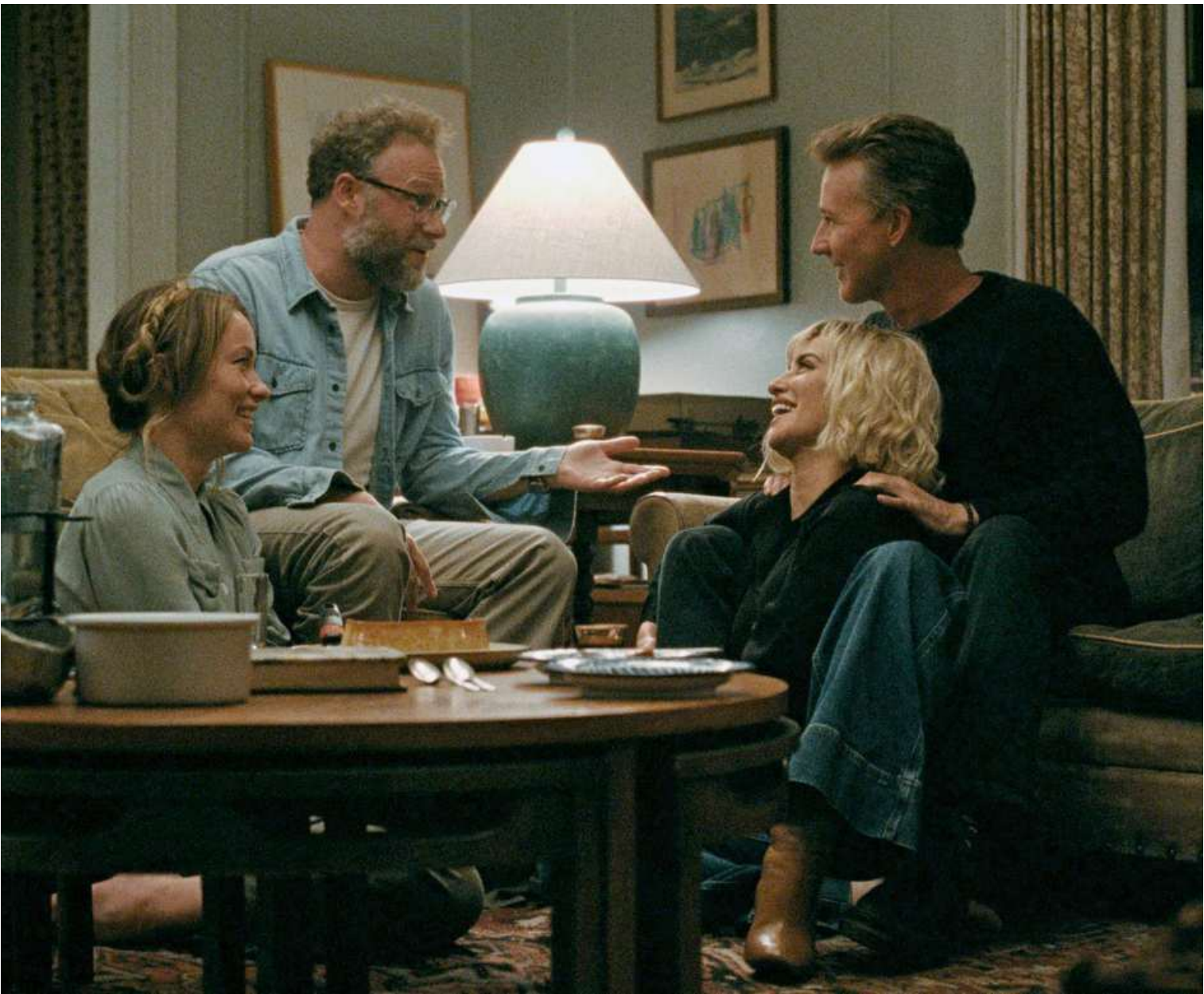


Prime Video series Adarsh Baal Vidyalaya locks release date

Kay Kay Menon will be headlining an upcoming Prime Video series, *Adarsh Baal Vidyalaya*. The streamer announced on July 9 that the series will be released on July 24 on the platform.

The comedy-drama is set in a dysfunctional school and follows its laid-back headmaster, Gyaneshwar Tripathi (Menon) rallying an unlikely team of teachers to improve the fortunes of the school, which happens to be the city's most underperforming.

The show has been directed by Himank Gaur and created and executive produced by Biswapati Sarkar and Sameer Saxena under the banner of Posham Pa Pictures.



A funny excavation of modern love

This deep dive into love, sex and relationships offers equal measures of sharp humour as well as uncomfortable insights

English

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How much do I love this movie? Let me count the ways. Is it the ferocious acting by the ensemble cast? The smart writing that is funny and razor sharp, slicing into the heart of relationships? The way the apartment, where almost all the action takes place, seems both large and small? Or the use of mirrors and windows to suggest reflection and looking in from the outside?

It was all this and more, keeping me furiously engaged throughout Olivia Wilde's 107-minute *The Invite*. A remake of Cesc Gay's 2020 Spanish film, *The People Upstairs*, itself an adaptation of his stage play, *The Invite* tells the story of a couple, Angela (Olivia Wilde) and Joe (Seth Rogen), whose marriage has reached breaking point thanks to forsaken dreams and disappointments.

The movie opens with an Oscar Wilde quote – "One should always be in love. That is the reason one should never marry." We see Joe teaching music and then going home, travelling on the train with his cycle and then pedalling up a steeply inclined San Francisco road before finally reaching his apartment and

The Invite

Director: Olivia Wilde

Cast: Seth Rogen, Olivia Wilde, Penélope Cruz, Edward Norton

Storyline: A couple invites their neighbours to dinner and the evening unravels into a litany of savage puns and unconventional revelations

promptly lying flat on the floor.

Angela seems to be in a frantic rush preparing to host a dinner for their neighbours, Hawk (Edward Norton) and Pina (Penélope Cruz), who live in the flat upstairs. Joe does not remember Angela telling him about the dinner, which Angela says is only natural as he never listens to anything she says.

Angela and Joe argue loudly about the dinner and their guests with Joe complaining of the couple's loud and noisy sex and insisting he is going to tell Pina and Hawk about it. Angela has gone to enormous trouble for the dinner, from sourcing a special Spanish ham to make Pina feel at home and preparing a soufflé and loaded charcuterie board to buying a new rug and top, much to Joe's annoyance.

Once Pina and Hawk arrive with Pina's amazing flan, things move into a higher gear. Hawk and Pina tell Joe they admire his blunt way of speaking and Hawk praises the new rug. As the evening progresses, the two couples learn surprising things about each other and themselves, including the fact that there are no perfect relationships.

Hawk and Pina also argue but are willing to talk it through. Joe and Angela, meanwhile, have drifted apart and away from their younger selves whose story began with Angela running 12 blocks to listen to Joe play.

There is a special joy in watching the four gifted actors at the top of their game

riffing off each other one acidic put down at a time. Wilde is coiled tighter than a spring while Cruz with her platinum blonde bob is all Latin warmth and sizzle. Norton might look boring but he has fire and that monologue about his name is wild making you feel you are brushing against genius. Rogen give Joe, a man who has given up his dreams of becoming a musician and hates the fact he is living in his parents' house, a rueful brilliance.

The film crackles with rapid-fire dialogue. From Hawk's no filter comments of loving a "contentious environment" and Joe's reply, "You hit the jackpot then, my friend" to Pina's "People forget they deserve more" the dialogue sparkles like a many-gemmed tiara.

The film, which is dedicated to Diane Keaton, who played Wilde's mother in *Love the Coopers*, is reminiscent of a gentler version of *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf*. Wilde has counted the film as well as others such as *Happiness*, *12 Angry Men* and *Scenes from a Marriage* as inspirations.

The music is delightful, with on-point needle drops from Sade to a sweet 1970 demo of CSNY's "Our House" by Graham Nash and Joni Mitchell. The fact that the film has been remade in French, Italian, Swiss and Korean speaks of its universality. *The Invite* can be a perfect date movie, go into it blind and you are in for the pleasantest surprise.

The Invite is currently running in theatres